

The King's Voice - Exodus 1 (Study)

The King's Voice

A Group Study on Exodus 1:15-22

Then the king of Egypt said to the Hebrew midwives, one of whom was named Shiphrah and the other Puah, "When you serve as midwife to the Hebrew women and see them on the birthstool, if it is a son, you shall kill him, but if it is a daughter, she shall live." But the midwives feared God and did not do as the king of Egypt commanded them, but let the male children live. So the king of Egypt called the midwives and said to them, "Why have you done this, and let the male children live?" The midwives said to Pharaoh, "Because the Hebrew women are not like the Egyptian women, for they are vigorous and give birth before the midwife comes to them." So God dealt well with the midwives. And the people multiplied and grew very strong. And because the midwives feared God, he gave them families. Then Pharaoh commanded all his people, "Every son that is born to the Hebrews you shall cast into the Nile, but every daughter you shall let live." (*Exodus 1:15-22, ESV*)

Background

- **Setting:** Jacob's family came to Egypt as 70 people (Genesis 46); by now, hundreds of thousands. The Pharaoh of Joseph's day is long dead.
 - **Dynasty:** Likely the 18th Dynasty of the New Kingdom (~1500s BC). Egypt had just expelled the Semitic Hyksos and was wary of growing Hebrew numbers.
 - **Unnamed Pharaoh:** Bible never names him. Egyptian kings built monuments, obelisks, and temples so their names would last forever. *The narrator's silence is theology:* the God of Israel decides whose names last.
 - **Birthstool** (Hebrew: *ovnayim*, "two stones") — the pair of bricks Egyptian women delivered on. Archaeologists have recovered a decorated birthing brick from this period at Abydos, painted with mother and newborn. Pharaoh's command targeted the threshold between womb and world.
 - **"Feared God"** (Hebrew: *yirat elohim*) — **not** terror. A *settled allegiance* — the orienting conviction that God's voice is the voice that finally counts. Loyalty, not panic. *This is the anchor phrase of the whole study.*
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Introduction

We live in a world of voices. Some of them are gentle — a nurse asking how you slept, a grandchild on the phone, a familiar song from the radio. Some of them are loud. The voice of a body that says, "you're not what you used to be." The voice of a calendar that says, "your turn was back then, not now." The voice of a culture that whispers, "you're in the way." Many voices speak into our lives — but not all have earned the right to be heard. Some carry more weight than they deserve.

Today's passage takes us back more than 3,000 years to a palace in Egypt. The loudest voice in the known world — Pharaoh's — was giving a terrible command to two ordinary women. What they did next changed the story of salvation forever. And what God did in return is a word of breathtaking comfort for anyone who has ever felt overlooked, forgotten, or caught between competing voices.

The question before us today is simple: **whose voice do you answer to?**

1. The Loud Voice

Focus: Exodus 1:15-16, 22 — *"Then the king of Egypt said to the Hebrew midwives... 'if it is a son, you shall kill him...' Then Pharaoh commanded all his people, 'Every son that is born to the Hebrews you shall cast into the Nile.'"*

Context / Setup

- Pharaoh's voice is **cold, bureaucratic, absolute** — not passion, but procedure. State-sanctioned killing in the dull language of policy.
- No debate, no naming of the crime — just the flat tone of every tyrant in history: *when you see... if it is a son... you shall.*
- **Escalation across Exodus 1:**
 - vv.1-14 → forced labor
 - v.16 → secret kill order to the midwives
 - v.22 → public decree to **all Egypt**: throw Hebrew boys in the Nile
- **The loud voice gets louder as it fails.** Loud voices always do.

Theological Anchor

- Pharaoh believed he was the living god of Egypt — when he spoke, the cosmos was supposed to obey.
- He had the empire, the armies, the Nile. He had no idea what two women were about to decide.
- **Loud does not mean final.** Pharaoh's voice was the loudest voice in Egypt; it was not the last voice.

Talking Points

- Loud voices **threaten, claim inevitability, act as if they're alone in the room.** None of that is the same as being right.
- The escalation itself is the tell — a truly sovereign voice does not need to keep shouting.
- Foreshadow Section 3: the one who shouts loudest here is the one the Bible refuses to name.

For Us

- Loud voices today rarely wear crowns, but still claim authority they haven't earned:
 - A **diagnosis** can start to sound like a verdict.
 - **Loss** can start to sound like the final word.
 - **Culture** whispers: old is in the way, limited = useless, your best days are behind you.
- *None of these voices are God.* They are loud. They are not last.
- **Refrain to plant:** *"loud is not final."*

Teaching Tip

If residents are comfortable, invite them to name aloud (or silently to themselves) one "loud voice" that keeps trying to speak over God's voice in their life this season. No one has to share. Just naming it weakens it.

Reflection Questions

1. What are the "loud voices" in your life right now — the ones that seem to have all the power? Are any of them speaking louder than they deserve to?
 2. Pharaoh's command got louder each time it failed. Have you noticed that the loudest voices in our lives are often the most insecure?
 3. When we are tired, sick, or lonely, it's easy to believe the loud voice. What helps *you* remember that loud doesn't mean final?
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2. The Quiet Voice

Focus: Exodus 1:17 — "*But the midwives feared God and did not do as the king of Egypt commanded them, but let the male children live.*"

Context / Setup

- No recorded speech from the midwives to God or about God — only a reported interior state: *they feared God*.
- No rally, no speech, no march on the palace. Two women **continue their ordinary work** and refuse to cross a line.
- The quietest resistance in the Bible is also one of the most consequential.

Theological Anchor

- **Fear of God orders all other fears beneath it.** When two voices compete — king vs. God — the one who fears God already knows whose voice wins.
- God does not need famous people to start the exodus. He needs **faithful** ones.
- The turning point of salvation history hinges on two middle-aged working women with rough hands and a long walk between houses.

Language Notes

- **Feared God** (Hebrew: *yirat elohim*) — not fear of punishment but *settled conviction* that God is the voice that counts. Allegiance, reverence, love.
- **Shiphrah & Puah** — not priests, not generals, not royalty. Working women whose names almost no one outside their neighborhood would have known.
 - Shiphrah means "to be pleasing" (i.e. fairness, beautiful)
 - Puah means "to be brilliant" (i.e. called-out, radiant)

Talking Points

- The text spotlights an *interior* event (they feared God) *before* an *exterior* action (they let the boys live). The inside comes first. It always does.
- Contrast: Pharaoh's voice commands through volume. God's voice commands through allegiance.
- This is not civil disobedience as protest — it is civil disobedience as **worship**. They were not making a point; they were keeping a loyalty.

For Us

- Most of us will never face a Pharaoh. Daily, we face **smaller moments where two voices compete**:
 - A sharp word rises — we swallow it.
 - An aide is short-tempered — we speak back with patience.
 - A lonely neighbor needs a visit — our knees hurt, but we go.
 - A grandchild calls — we tell the truth, gently.
- **These are the birthing stones of our age.** Ordinary work. Quiet choices. One life at a time let to live.
- Fear of God does not always look brave. Sometimes it looks like:
 - Staying in your chair and praying when others have decided prayer is a waste.
 - Telling a staff member "thank you" when no one else has all day.
 - Refusing the gossip, refusing the bitterness, choosing hope one more time before bed.
- The midwives didn't storm the palace. **They just did their quiet work — with God as their ultimate boss.**

Teaching Tip

If the group is ready for it, explore the difference between *fearing God* (settled allegiance, reverence, love) and being *afraid of God* (terror, shame, hiding). The first drives us toward him; the second drives us away. "Perfect love casts out fear" (1 John 4:18) speaks of the second kind, not the first.

Reflection Questions

1. The midwives' great act of faith was simply to keep doing their ordinary work with God as their ultimate authority. What is *your* ordinary work right now — the small, daily thing God has given you to do?
2. "Fear of God" is a settled conviction about whose voice counts most. In your experience, what helps the quiet voice of God stay loud enough to hear over the louder voices around you?
3. Can you think of a time in your own life when a small, quiet act of faithfulness turned out to matter far more than you knew at the time?

3. The Lasting Voice

Focus: Exodus 1:20-21 — *"So God dealt well with the midwives. And the people multiplied and grew very strong. And because the midwives feared God, he gave them families."*

Context / Setup

- After seven verses of Pharaoh shouting, a different voice speaks — **not in a recorded word, but in action.** *So God dealt well with the midwives.*
- God **saw** what they did in the dark of birthing rooms. God **heard** the silence when Pharaoh's command was not obeyed. God **noticed**.

Theological Anchor

- **"He gave them families"** is the narrator's understatement. The Hebrew literally says, *"he built for them houses."*

- This is the **language of royal dynasty** — the same phrase God uses with King David: *"I will build you a house"* (2 Samuel 7:11).
- **Two no-name midwives are granted the kind of legacy the Bible usually reserves for kings.**
- The great reversal: the god-king commissioned pyramids, statues, temples, obelisks to make his name last forever. The Bible **does not record his name once**. Scholars are still not sure which Pharaoh he was.
- But *Shiphrah* and *Puah*? In Scripture forever. Read in every language on earth. Read for 3,000 years. Read 10,000 years from now if the Lord tarries.

Language Notes

- **"He built them houses"** (Hebrew idiom, v.21) — dynastic legacy language; parallels 2 Samuel 7:11 (David) and 1 Samuel 2:35 (a faithful priest). God builds *houses* for those who build his people.

Talking Points

- **Monuments vs. memory.** Pharaoh spent a treasury making his name last and the Bible stepped around it. Two midwives were faithful and God carved their names into eternity.
- This is not irony. It is policy. *This is how God keeps score.*
- The one who shouts to be remembered is forgotten. The ones who feared God are named forever. **This is the voice that lasts.**

For Us

- Many of you have spent a lifetime doing work the world did not notice:
 - Children raised.
 - A spouse cared for through illness.
 - Showing up at church when it was inconvenient.
 - Sunday school kids whose names you can barely remember.
 - Prayers for people who never thanked you.
- **Most of the world doesn't have a file on you. Heaven does.**
- The God who named Shiphrah and Puah:
 - **Knows your name.**
 - **Remembers what the world forgets.**
 - **Writes what the world doesn't publish.**
 - **Treasures what the world throws away.**
- You are not forgotten. You have never been forgotten.
- **Anchor verse:** *"Your Father who sees in secret will reward you."* (Matthew 6:4)

Reflection Questions

1. Pharaoh built monuments so his name would last, and the Bible doesn't even record it. The midwives did ordinary faithful work, and their names are in Scripture forever. What does that tell you about the kinds of things God keeps?
2. Is there a quiet, faithful act in your own life — something no one else has ever thanked you for — that you think God has been keeping?

3. How does it change the way you face this week to know that the God who named Shiphrah and Puah also knows your name?

For Reflection

Two things to carry with you this week:

- **Listen for the voices.**
 - When discouraged, afraid, or feeling small, ask: *whose voice is this?*
 - The loud voice of culture, or body, or regret — or the quiet voice of the God who has the last word?
 - Name the loud voice for what it is.
 - Refrain, spoken softly to yourself: *"loud is not final."*
 - **Live as one who is named.**
 - You are not one of the forgotten.
 - Every ordinary act of faithfulness this week — a prayer whispered in your chair, a kindness to a nurse, a phone call to a lonely friend, a smile to a new resident — is written down where it counts.
 - Do your small, faithful work.
 - *The God who named Shiphrah and Puah is keeping your name too.*
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If Time Permits: Cross-References

- **Matthew 6:4** — *"Your Father who sees in secret will reward you."*
 - **Luke 1:46-55** (the Magnificat) — *"He has put down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate."* Mary's song is the same song Shiphrah and Puah were already living.
 - **Matthew 10:28** — *"Do not fear those who kill the body... rather fear him."* The New Testament commentary on verse 17.
 - **Acts 5:29** — *"We must obey God rather than men."* The apostles standing in a long line with two midwives.
 - **Hebrews 6:10** — *"God is not unjust so as to overlook your work and the love that you have shown for his name."*
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Closing prayer suggestion: Thank God that he names the unnamed and keeps what the world forgets. Ask him to quiet the loud voices and sharpen our ear for his. Pray by name for any residents who need particular strength this week. Close with the Lord's Prayer.